

SPELMAN CHRISTMAS

An Atlanta family arrives home for the holidays — and finds their mother has already canceled them.

FORMAT Feature Film • 93 pp • ~100 min	GENRE Holiday Family Dramedy	PLATFORM TARGET OWN • BET+ (Lifetime secondary)	SETTING West End, Atlanta / Spelman College
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LOGLINE

A grieving Spelman English professor swears off Christmas the year after burying her chaplain husband — until her three headstrong daughters descend on the family home uninvited, quietly volunteer her for the very public tradition she buried with him, and force her to choose between her pride and finally letting them see her fall apart.

SYNOPSIS

Dr. Geneva Ellis has crossed December 25th off her calendar. A year after losing Charles — a beloved Spelman chaplain who built the College's Candlelight tradition from nothing — the Dean of English has boxed up his suits, declined this year's reflection, and told her daughters there will be no Christmas. They come home anyway: Zora, the corporate fixer who negotiates PTO like a hostile takeover; Simone, the free spirit who's kept an engagement secret for a year; and Imani, the youngest, carrying a secret of her own. What starts as an ambush of ginger root and inner peace turns into a real reckoning when Zora, trying to give her mother a reason to leave the house, tells Spelman's president Geneva will deliver the reflection after all — and the lie goes public at the neighborhood's Christmas Jazz Night, in front of the dean who raised Geneva herself. With days until Christmas Eve and a printed program she can't take back, Geneva has to decide what her word is worth, what her daughters are allowed to carry for her, and whether being known is a kind of failure or the whole point.

THEMES

- **Inherited armor** — the cost of excellence passed down as protection, and what it takes to set it down.
- **Public self vs. private grief** — a woman who has spent her career teaching other women to be seen, unable to let herself be.
- **Chosen family** — an outsider fiancé earning his place without becoming the story.
- **Legacy as a living thing** — what a Spelman education, and a Spelman marriage, actually cost the woman living inside them.

COMPARABLE TITLES

- The Christmas Showdown (OWN, 2025)
- Queens of Christmas (BET+, 2025)
- Steel Magnolias
- Waiting to Exhale

WHY NOW / WHY NCCA

OWN and BET+ closed 2025 leaning hard into Black-joy holiday programming built around ensemble casts and multigenerational catharsis — and into specific HBCU cultural texture over generic backdrop. *Spelman Christmas* is built for that exact lane: a single-location, contained ensemble piece (one home, one campus, one event space) with the emotional scale of a much bigger production. NCCA's Atlanta base and HBCU-adjacent relationships make the Spelman specificity a producible asset, not a research problem.

SPELMAN CHRISTMAS

A working wish list, not an offer sheet — matched for age, register, and current lane fit. Several names below are actively working in this exact OWN/BET+ holiday-ensemble space right now, which is noted where relevant.

DR. GENEVA ELLIS — LEAD, 60s

Spelman English professor; widow, the family's "Dean of stone." Needs precision, buried warmth, and a real fall from control in Act Three.

Vanessa Bell Calloway

Currently headlining BET+'s *Queens of Christmas* (2025) — exactly the regal-thawing register this role needs, and already proven with this audience.

Lynn Whitfield

Prestige gravitas (*Greenleaf*, *Being Mary Jane*); brings the "Spelman legend" weight Geneva's reputation requires.

S. Epatha Merkerson

Active 2025 (*Eye for an Eye*); could play Geneva's control harder-edged and more procedural — a compelling alternate read.

DEAN MARION TURNER — SUPPORTING, 80s

Retired Spelman legend, Geneva's mentor since 1984. Needs to command a chapel full of people with a single line.

Loretta Devine

Currently in OWN's *The Christmas Showdown* (2025) — warmth and institutional authority in one package; a name the target audience already trusts.

Anna Maria Horsford

Reliable, beloved matriarch-of-the-institution presence; comic timing to lighten the chapel confrontation.

CCH Pounder

A steelier alternate read — Dean Turner as someone Geneva is a little afraid of, not just fond of.

ZORA — SUPPORTING LEAD, 34

Oldest daughter, corporate fixer, the one who volunteers Geneva for the reflection. Needs comic precision that curdles into real vulnerability.

Kiki Layne

Currently starring in OWN's *Fake Yourself a Merry Little Christmas* (2025) — proven in this exact lane this exact season.

DeWanda Wise

Controlled, high-wattage energy that can snap into raw emotion for the chapel breakdown.

Yvonne Orji

Comic snap for the "holiday efficiency plan" beats, with real dramatic range underneath.

SIMONE — SUPPORTING LEAD, 30

Middle daughter, free-spirited, keeping a year-long engagement secret. Needs warmth and a live wire of fear underneath the incense and crystal grids.

Amber Stevens West

Currently in OWN's *The Christmas Showdown* (2025) — warm, textured comic-dramatic range already in the right register.

Logan Browning

Grounded contemporary presence; can carry the wedding-fear material without tipping into melodrama.

Zazie Beetz

Offbeat specificity for the "Wicca phase" texture — a slightly riskier, more original read.

IMANI — SUPPORTING LEAD, 25

Youngest daughter, law student, quietly pregnant. The emotional throughline of the ensemble — needs to hold a full scene alone with the lead.

Alexis Chikaeze

Rising profile (*All American*); right age, proven warmth on camera, room to grow into a lead.

Storm Reid

Proven range aging into 20s leads that need both youth and real gravity.

Xosha Roquemore

Comic timing for the "pickles at 2 a.m." beats, with clear access to the vulnerability underneath.

CLAY — SUPPORTING, 30s

Simone's fiancé, white, earnest outsider learning the family's language in real time. Needs to be funny without ever becoming the joke.

Ben Rappaport
Warm, slightly anxious energy (*The Good Wife*, *For the People*) — reads as genuine, not performative.

Chris Lowell
Comedic-earnest range (*GLOW*) that can still land the campus-walk confession scene straight.

John Gallagher Jr.
Understated, grounded — a quieter read that lets Simone's family stay the loudest thing in the room.

Casting suggestions reflect age, tone, and current-lane fit as of this document's preparation and are not confirmed availability or attachment. Several names above are drawn from active 2025–2026 OWN and BET+ holiday programming as a signal of proven audience fit for this genre.